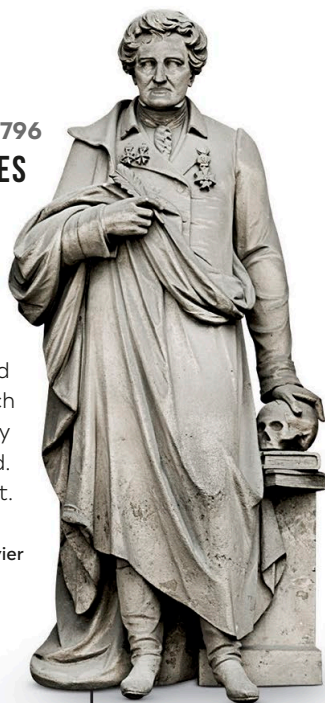


1796

GEORGES CUVIER ESTABLISHES EXTINCTION AS FACT

Naturalists of the 18th century could not countenance that creatures – then believed to have been created by a perfect God – could become extinct. By comparing the anatomy of fossilized animals with living ones, the French zoologist Cuvier established that many species had indeed vanished. Extinction was a fact.

▷ Statue of Georges Cuvier



1795

1795 The British seize territory from the Dutch in the Cape of Good Hope, South Africa

1796 The Qianlong Emperor abdicates, sending China's Qing empire into decline

1797 French soldiers land in Fishguard, Wales, in the War of the First Coalition

▽ Members of the White Lotus Society



1796

WHITE LOTUS REBELLION

The millenarian White Lotus Society was a cult dedicated to overthrowing the Manchu Qing dynasty. In response to famine and persecution, the Society led a rebellion against the Qing that took eight years and enormous expense to quell. Around 100,000 rebels died during the revolt, as did the myth of Manchu military invincibility.



△ Hanaoka Seishū, *Surgical Casebook*

1796

GENERAL ANAESTHESIA DEVELOPED IN JAPAN

Hanaoka Seishū, a Japanese surgeon of the Edo period, began developing a plant-derived compound named *tsūsensan* that could render patients unconscious for 6–24 hours. By 1804, he had perfected his formula and was able to successfully perform the world's first surgery using general anaesthesia.